# Should I translate my research idea into practice?

*A 10-Minute Diagnostic Guide and Workbook for Researchers and Clinicians*

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*Work through each question honestly. There are no wrong answers — only clearer directions. This framework helps you assess readiness, fit, and pathway before committing time, funding, or identity to translation.*

**You have a research idea or clinical insight**

Q1 · PROBLEM VALIDITY

### Is there a clear, unmet need that your idea directly addresses?

*Think: patient burden, clinical gap, system inefficiency, or evidence void. Can you name it in one sentence?*

**YES — Continue** | **NO → See right**

→ Q1 IF NO

**Strengthen the problem definition first**

Conduct a focused needs assessment, patient or clinician interviews, or a landscape review. Return once the problem is clearly defined.

Q2 · DIFFERENTIATION

### Does your idea offer something genuinely different from existing solutions?

*Consider: better efficacy, lower cost, more accessible, simpler to use, or more equitable delivery.*

**YES — Continue** | **NO → See right**

→ Q2 IF NO

**Refine or reconsider**

Existing solutions may be sufficient. Explore whether meaningful improvement — not invention — is the real opportunity.

Q3 · EVIDENCE READINESS

### Do you have proof of concept — data, pilots, or early validation?

*Lab data, case series, feasibility study, or structured patient/clinician feedback counts.*

**YES — Continue** | **NO → See right**

→ Q3 IF NO

**Build proof of concept first**

Apply for exploratory funding (NIH R21, NSF SBIR, foundation grants). Design a small validation study before committing to translation.

Q4 · PATHWAY CLARITY

### Do you know how this would reach patients, clinicians, or the system?

*Options: spinout company, IP licensing, NHS adoption, academic partnership, or commercial partner.*

**YES — Continue** | **NO → See right**

→ Q4 IF NO

**Map the ecosystem first**

Engage your Technology Transfer Office (TTO), innovation hub, or outside consultants. Attend an accelerator programme or translation workshop before proceeding.

Q5 · PERSONAL FIT

### Are you willing and positioned to lead or champion this idea?

*Consider: time availability, risk tolerance, non-research work appetite, institutional support, co-founders.*

**YES — Ready to lead** | **NO — Not ready yet**

✓ TRANSLATE NOW

**You are ready to begin the translation journey**

Engage your Technology Transfer Office (TTO) or innovation office. Protect IP if needed. Define your 90-day next steps and identify your core team.

→ LICENSE OR HAND OFF

**The idea has merit — but you may not be the one to lead it**

Consider licensing the IP, finding a co-founder champion, or publishing fully to enable others to build on the work.

- **Continue** — Follow YES → to the next question
- **Develop First** — Strengthen before translating
- **Translate Now** — Begin the formal process
- **Redirect** — Different pathway or person

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# Worked Example & Your Project Evaluation

## Example Case — AI-Assisted Breast Cancer Detection

SCENARIO A research lab develops a novel AI model to assist radiologists in detecting early signs of breast cancer from imaging data.

**Problem Validity — STRONG**
Surgeons and radiologists confirm early detection remains a major clinical need and missed lesions are a significant problem in practice.

**Differentiation — MODERATE**
Several AI tools exist for breast imaging, but this model may improve detection sensitivity in specific underserved patient groups.

**Evidence Readiness — WEAK**
Trained on retrospective datasets only. Prospective clinical validation has not yet been performed and is required before translation.

**Pathway Clarity — UNCLEAR**
Regulatory strategy is undefined. Unclear whether a 510(k) pathway or De Novo FDA submission is appropriate for this device type.

RECOMMENDATION
Strengthen evidence and clarify the regulatory pathway before pursuing startup formation or large clinical trials.

→ Design a prospective validation study
→ Engage regulatory expertise (FDA pathway)
→ Evaluate radiology workflow integration

## YOUR PROJECT Apply the framework to your own idea — type directly into each field below

**Describe your idea or project in 1–2 sentences** *(your scenario)*

**Q1 · Problem Validity** *Is there a clear unmet need? Who confirmed it?*

**Q2 · Differentiation** *What makes your idea different from existing solutions?*

**Q3 · Evidence Readiness** *What evidence do you have? What validation is still needed?*

**Q4 · Pathway Clarity** *How would this reach patients? Is the pathway defined?*

**Q5 · Personal Fit** *Are you willing and able to lead this?*

**Your Recommendation** *What is your overall assessment and decision?*

**My Next Steps** *List 3 concrete actions based on your evaluation above*

**Additional Comments** *Any further reflections, questions, or blockers*

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